

No less importantly, for the first time, factories were forced to provide sanitary provisions as basic as toilets for their workers. There had been none in the Triangle Company's premises. One reason that exits were locked was to prevent "interruption of work" if employees left the building to use a lavatory. As one young factory worker said of her work conditions, "Unsantitary. That's the word that is generally used, but there ought to be a worse one."

While the political response was partly one of self-interest—that political figures could boost their public standing if they were seen to be on the side of the workers rather than the bosses—it was also genuinely disinterested. There was a recognition that no country as forward-looking and enterprising as the United States could hope to

After organizing a march to protest against the loss of life in the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory fire, unions worked with reform-minded politicians to introduce tougher safety regulations.

prosper if it persisted with labor laws so obviously skewed against its working people. Roosevelt's 1933 New Deal was a direct result of the lesson learned from the Triangle fire: capitalism was best served if it genuinely had the interests of all at heart.

Modern parallels

The Triangle Shirtwaist Factory was manufacturing the shirts made popular by the rise of independent, adventurous young American women breaking free from the constraints of home and hearth, forging new careers in offices in cities across the United States. Their carefree garments and the new freedoms they symbolized were made possible only by forced labor that was scarcely any better than a form of slavery. The 1911 fire exposed the poor working conditions in garment factories at the time, but the parallels with 21st-century sweatshops in many parts of Asia that make fashion so cheap and fast-changing in the affluent West are striking. ■



Frances Perkins

A number of New York legislators actively responded to the challenge presented by the Triangle Factory fire. They stood in stark contrast to their predecessors at the New York-based political organization Tammany Hall. Among the most notable were Alfred E. Smith, Robert F. Wagner, and Charles F. Murphy. The most important, however, was a woman.

Frances Perkins, born in 1880, witnessed the Triangle fire, and it was perhaps the defining moment of her life. She had already campaigned fiercely for workers' rights, but her subsequent commitment to social justice was rewarded in 1933, when President Roosevelt made her secretary of labor—the first female member of any US cabinet. As much as anyone, Perkins can lay serious claim to be a prime shaper of the New Deal. She remained in office until the end of Roosevelt's presidency in 1945 and is known today not just as the longest-serving secretary of labor, but also as an early champion of women's rights. She died in New York City in 1965.

